

A DEADLY WAVE Body bags of Covid victims kept next to patients on ventilators in a Hong Kong hospital

Foundation of India (PHFI). While the now famous IIT-Kanpur model has predicted that a fourth wave will hit India by June 22, experts say that three major factors will determine when the country will witness the next wave and how impactful it will be. The first is how well we handle the growing pandemic fatigue, then the rise of new Covid variants and, finally, the vaccine booster coverage for the vulnerable.

BATTLING PANDEMIC FATIGUE

China is a glaring example of how strict lockdowns alone are not enough to stall the pandemic. With its 'zero Covid tolerance' policy, China had one of the world's most stringent lockdowns and travel restrictions in place, which kept it mostly virus-free. But as soon as the country began to lift restrictions in January, a wave of infections took over causing deaths again. On March 19, mainland China recorded its first Covid death since January 25, 2021, followed by another on March 21. Compared to this, China had seen only two Covid-releated deaths in all of 2021 even as other countries reported thousands of losses in the face of the deadly Delta wave. In Hong Kong, with 20,000 new cases reported in a single day on March



"IT IS EXTREMELY IMPORTANT THAT INDIANS WHO ARE **ABOVE 60 YEARS OF AGE AND HAVE COMORBID CONDITIONS** BE PROTECTED AGAINST COVID"

Dr V.K. PAUL
Chairman, National Expert Group on Vaccine Administration for COVID-19